“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Madhya-līlā

Chapter 25

The Residents of Vārāṇasī Become Vaiṣṇavas

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 Having made Vaiṣṇavas of the residents of Kāśī, headed by the *sannyāsīs*, and having thoroughly refined Sanātana, the Lord went to Nīlādri.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 In this way, for two months, Mahāprabhu taught him the utmost limit of the conclusions of *bhakti*.

4 Paramānanda Kīrtanīyā, the companion of Candraśekhara, sang *kīrtana* for the Lord, and he did it with great delight.

5 When the *sannyāsīs* disregarded the Lord, mercy toward them arose in Him, so that He might dispel the sorrow of His devotees.

6 I have described the Lord’s mercy to the *sannyāsīs* before, in detail. Here I mention it again, briefly.

7 Everywhere the *sannyāsīs* blasphemed the Lord. Hearing this, a *brāhmaṇa* from Mahārāṣṭra reflected sorrowfully:

8 “Whoever sees the Lord’s nature at close hand perceives who He truly is and accepts Him as Īśvara, the Supreme Lord.

9 If by some means I can bring them together, the *sannyāsīs* will see this and become His devotees.

10 I live in Vārāṇasī permanently. If I do not do this, I shall be sorry for ever.”

11 Thinking thus, he invited all the *sannyāsīs*. Then that *brāhmaṇa* came to the place where Mahāprabhu was staying.

12 At that time Candraśekhara and Tapana Miśra, pained to hear the blasphemy, appealed at the Lord’s feet.

13 Seeing His devotees’ sorrow, the Lord reflected within Himself, and the wish arose in Him to turn the hearts of the *sannyāsīs*.

14 Just then the *brāhmaṇa* came and invited Him. With great humility he clasped the Lord’s feet.

15 Mahāprabhu then accepted his invitation, and the next day, after His midday duties, He went to his house.

16 How the Lord delivered the *sannyāsīs* there I have told in detail in the account of the Pañca-tattva.

17 The book would grow long, and it would be told again; so I write here only what I did not write there.

18 From the day the Lord showed mercy to the *sannyāsīs*, the whole town was astir.

19 Crowds of people came to see the Lord, and scholars learned in various scriptures came to discuss scripture with Him.

20 Refuting every argument from the scriptures, the Lord established *bhakti* as their essence, and with well-reasoned words He turned everyone's mind.

21 Accepting His instruction, they performed *kṛṣṇa-saṅkīrtana*; all the people laughed, sang and danced.

22 The *sannyāsīs* bowed down to the Lord. Giving up their studies, they discussed Him among themselves.

23 One disciple of Prakāśānanda, his equal, spoke in the assembly, honouring the Lord:

24 "Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya is Nārāyaṇa Himself. He explains the meaning of the *Vyāsa-sūtra* most charmingly.

25 He explains the primary meaning of the Upaniṣads, and hearing it soothes the minds and ears of the learned.

26 Abandoning the primary meaning of the *sūtras* and the Upaniṣads, the Ācārya (Śaṅkara) insists on his own imaginings.

27 When a scholar hears the meaning the Ācārya imagined, his mouth says 'Yes, yes,' but his heart does not accept it.

28 I accept the words of Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya as firmly true: in the age of Kali one does not conquer *saṁsāra* by *sannyāsa*.

29 The explanation He gave of the *harer nāma* verse is true; its meaning gives joy, and it is the supreme evidence.

30 The *Bhāgavata* says that without *bhakti* there is no liberation, and in the age of Kali liberation comes easily by *nāmābhāsa*, the mere semblance of the holy name.

31 “O almighty Lord, bhakti to You is the path to the highest good. Those who reject it and toil only to gain knowledge are left with nothing but their toil, like those who pound empty husks.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.14.4)

32 “O lotus-eyed Lord, others think themselves liberated, but their intelligence is impure, for they have no love for You. Though they rise with great hardship to the supreme position, they fall down from there, having neglected Your feet.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.2.32)

33 The word ‘Brahman’ means Bhagavān, full of the six opulences. To establish Him as without attributes (*nirviśeṣa*) is to diminish His completeness.

34 The *śrutis* and the Purāṇas speak of the play of Kṛṣṇa’s spiritual potency (*cic-chakti-vilāsa*). Not accepting this, the scholar mocks it.

35 To regard Kṛṣṇa’s form of spirit and bliss as *māyic* is a great sin. Caitanya’s words are true.

36 “O Supreme Lord, I see nothing higher than this form of Yours, which is pure bliss, free of all difference, its radiance unobscured. You are the one creator of the universe, yet You are distinct from it, O Self, and You are the source of the elements and the senses. I have taken shelter of that form of Yours.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.9.3)

37 “O good of all the worlds, this very form You have shown in meditation to us, Your worshippers, for our good. We bow down to You, Bhagavān, whom those bound for hell, attached to false arguments, do not honour.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.9.4)

38 “Fools disregard Me when I appear in a humanlike form, not knowing My supreme nature as the great Lord of all beings.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 9.11)

39 “Those envious and cruel men, the lowest of mankind and impure, I perpetually cast into the cycles of birth and death, into demonic wombs.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 16.19)

40 Not accepting the doctrine of transformation (*pariṇāma-vāda*) taught in the *sūtras*, he establishes *vivarta-vāda*, saying that Vyāsa was mistaken.

41 Such an imagined meaning does not appeal to the mind. Abandoning the scriptures, he explains his wicked fancies to the *pāṣaṇḍīs*.

42 Inquiry into the highest truth is gone; we only argue. How shall we gain liberation, and how Kṛṣṇa’s grace?

43 The Ācārya has covered the meaning of the *Vyāsa-sūtra*. This word of Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya is true.

44 Whatever Caitanya Gosāñi says is the essential doctrine; all other doctrines are worthless.”

45 Having said this, he began *kṛṣṇa-saṅkīrtana*. Hearing him, Prakāśānanda spoke:

46 “The Ācārya was determined to establish *advaita-vāda*, and so he explained the *sūtras* in another way.

47 If one accepts that He is Bhagavān (*bhagavattā*), *advaita* cannot be established. Therefore he refutes all the scriptures.

48 When an author wants to establish his own doctrine, the natural meaning of the scriptures does not come from him.

49 The Mīmāṁsaka says that Īśvara is a limb of *karma*. The Sāṅkhya says that *prakṛti* is the cause of the world.

50 The Nyāya says that the universe arises from atoms. The Māyāvādī calls the impersonal Brahman the cause.

51 The Pātañjala says that Īśvara is the realisation of one's own nature. In the view of the Vedas, He is called Svayam Bhagavān, the Lord Himself.

52 Vyāsa overturned the six doctrines of the six schools, and with all those *sūtras* he set forth the Vedānta.

53 In the view of Vedānta, Brahman is defined as having form (*sākāra*). By negation, the word *nirguṇa* shows that He is *saguṇa*, possessed of [transcendental] qualities.

54 None of them accepts Īśvara as the supreme cause. Each establishes his own doctrine by refuting the doctrines of others.

55 So we do not come to know the truth from the six philosophies. What the *mahājanas* say, that we accept as truth.

56 "Argument is inconclusive, the śrutis differ from one another, and there is no sage whose opinion does not differ from the others. The truth of dharma is hidden in the cave of the heart; the path is the one by which the great souls have gone." (Mahābhārata, Vana-parva, 313.117)

57 The words of Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya are a stream of nectar. Whatever He declares is the truth, the very essence."

58 Hearing all this, the *brāhmaṇa* from Mahārāṣṭra happily went to tell the Lord.

59 At that time Mahāprabhu, having bathed at Pañcanada, was on His way to see Lord Bindu-mādhava.

60 On the way the *brāhmaṇa* told Him everything. Hearing it, Mahāprabhu smiled a little with pleasure.

61 Seeing the beauty of Mādhava, He was overwhelmed with ecstasy, and coming into the courtyard, He began to dance in love.

62 Candraśekhara, Paramānanda, Tapana and Sanātana — these four together performed *saṅkīrtana* of the holy name:

63 "*Hari haraye namaḥ, kṛṣṇa yādavāya namaḥ, gopāla govinda rāma śrī-madhusūdana*."

64 On all sides hundreds of thousands of people called out, "Hari! Hari!" An auspicious sound arose, filling heaven and earth.

65 Hearing the sound of "Hari" nearby, Prakāśānanda came out of curiosity to see, bringing his disciples with him.

66 Seeing the Lord's dance, His love and the sweetness of His form, he too, with his disciples, called out, "Hari! Hari!"

67 Seeing joy, humility, restlessness and the other transient emotions (*sañcārī*) transforming Him, the people of Kāśī were amazed.

68 When the Lord returned to outer awareness and saw the crowds of people and the *sannyāsīs*, He checked His dancing.

69 The Lord honoured Prakāśānanda's feet, and Prakāśānanda came forward and clasped the Lord's feet.

70 The Lord said, "You are the guru of the world, most worthy of worship. I am not equal even to a disciple of your disciple.

71 Why should you, who are superior, honour one who is inferior? It is My total ruin, for you are like Brahman.

72 Although to you everything appears as Brahman, for the sake of teaching the people you should not act in this way."

73 He said, "The blasphemy of You that I committed before has all been destroyed by the touch of Your feet."

74 "Even those liberated in this life fall back into worldly desires if they offend Bhagavān, whose potencies are great and inconceivable." (a saying of the *Pariśiṣṭa*, quoted in the *Vāsanā-bhāṣya*)

75 "His sins destroyed by the touch of the Lord's beautiful feet, he gave up his serpent's body and took the form honoured by the Vidyādharas." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.34.9)

76 The Lord said, "Viṣṇu! Viṣṇu! I am a tiny, lowly *jīva*. To regard a *jīva* as Viṣṇu is the mark of an offender.

77 One who thinks a *jīva* to be Viṣṇu, and one who regards Nārāyaṇa as equal to Brahmā and Rudra, are counted among the *pāṣaṇḍīs*."

78 "One who looks upon the Lord Nārāyaṇa as equal to Brahmā, Rudra and the other gods is surely a *pāṣaṇḍī*." (Vaiṣṇava-tantra)

79 Prakāśānanda said, “You are Bhagavān Himself. Even so, if You think of Yourself as His servant,

80 You are still more worthy of worship than all of us. Blaspheming You has brought me total ruin.

81 “O great sage, even among millions of the liberated and the perfected, one devoted to Nārāyaṇa, whose mind is at peace, is very rare.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 6.14.5)

82 “Offence against great souls destroys a man’s life, fortune, fame and *dharma*, his higher worlds and blessings — all that is good for him.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.4.46)

83 “So long as people do not accept a bath in the dust of the feet of the great, who own nothing (*niṣkiñcana*), their minds cannot touch the feet of Urukrama, whose purpose is to remove all *anarthas*.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 7.5.32)

84 Now devotion to Your lotus feet will arise in me; for that I bow down at Your feet.”

85 Having said this, he sat down there with the Lord, and Prakāśānanda began to question Him:

86 “All the faults You have shown in Māyāvāda — we all know them to come from the Ācārya’s imagined interpretation.

87 You have explained the primary meaning of the *sūtras*, and hearing it, everyone’s mind was filled with wonder.

88 You are Īśvara; all potencies are Yours. Please tell it briefly — I wish to hear it.”

89 The Lord said, “I am a *jīva*, and My knowledge is very meagre. The meaning of the *Vyāsa-sūtra* is deep, and Vyāsa is Bhagavān.

90 No *jīva* knows the meaning of his *sūtras*; therefore he himself has explained their meaning.

91 When the author of the *sūtras* himself explains them, people come to know their original meaning.

92 The meaning of the *praṇava* (*oṁ*) is contained in the Gāyatrī, and the Catuḥ-ślokī, the four essential verses, unfolds that same meaning.

93 The Catuḥ-ślokī that Īśvara spoke to Brahmā, Brahmā taught to Nārada.

94 Nārada told that meaning to Vyāsa, and hearing it, Veda-vyāsa reflected within himself:

95 ‘This meaning accords with the explanation of my *sūtras*. I shall make the *Bhāgavata* the commentary on my *sūtras*.’

96 Whatever there is in the four Vedas and the Upaniṣads, Vyāsa took its meaning and gathered it together.

97 Whatever Vedic mantra (*ṛk*) states the subject of a *sūtra*, that same mantra is set down in a verse of the *Bhāgavata*.

98 Therefore the *Śrī Bhāgavata* is the commentary on the *Brahma-sūtra*. The verses of the *Bhāgavata* and the Upaniṣads teach one and the same doctrine.

99 “This universe and whatever moves within it are pervaded by the Lord. Enjoy what He has allotted to you, and do not covet anyone else’s wealth.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 8.1.10)

100 The *sambandha*, *abhidheya* and *prayojana* of the *Bhāgavata* are clearly defined in the Catuḥ-ślokī.

101 ‘I am the truth of *sambandha*, and knowledge and realisation of Me [belong to it]. *Sādhana-bhakti*, the means of attaining Me, is called *abhidheya*.

102 The fruit of *sādhana* is *prema*, the chief goal (*prayojana*). By that love the *jīva* attains service to Me.

103 “Receive from Me, as I speak it, the supremely confidential knowledge of Myself, endowed with realisation, together with its secret and that secret’s integral part.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.30)

104 I have told you these three truths. You are a *jīva*; you could not know these three [by yourself].

105 As My form is, as My abode is, and as My qualities, deeds, six opulences and potencies are,

106 may all this be revealed to you by My mercy.’ Saying this, He told him the three truths.

107 “By My grace may you truly realise Me as I am — My being, My forms, My qualities and My deeds.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.31)

108 ‘Before creation I exist, full of the six opulences, and the manifest world (*prapañca*), *prakṛti* and the *puruṣa* lie merged in Me.

109 Having created it, I dwell within it; and all this world that you see is also I, [as My energy].

110 At dissolution I alone remain, complete, and the material world dissolves into Me.

111 “Before creation I alone existed; there was nothing else — neither effect, nor cause, nor That which is beyond them. After creation this whole world is not other than Me, and what remains after its dissolution is also I.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.32)

112 The word *aham*, ‘I’, appears three times in the verse *aham eva*. It establishes the existence of His form, full of all opulence.

113 This was set down to rebuke one who does not accept His form and holds Him to be formless.

114 In all these words lies the discernment of *jñāna* and *vijñāna*: I am distinct from the works of *māyā* and from *māyā* itself.

115 Just as a reflection (*ābhāsa*) appears in place of the sun, yet has no manifestation of its own without the sun,

116 so one realises Me only on going beyond *māyā*. I have told you the truth of *sambandha*; now hear all the rest.

117 “Whatever appears to exist apart from Me, the Reality, and does not appear in Me, know that to be My māyā, like a reflection and like darkness.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.33)

118 Now hear the consideration of *abhidheya*, *sādhana-bhakti*, which extends to all people in every place, time and circumstance.

119 In matters of *dharma* and the rest these four considerations apply, but *sādhana-bhakti* is beyond them.

120 In every place, time and circumstance it is the duty of all people to ask the guru about that *bhakti* and to hear of it from him.

121 “This much must be inquired into by one who seeks the truth of the Self: That which exists everywhere and always, both directly and indirectly.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.35)

122 Love for Me — that *prema* is the *prayojana*. I describe its essential nature through its effects.

123 Just as the five elements are within and without all beings, so I am manifest without and within My devotees.

124 “As the great elements enter all beings, great and small, and yet remain outside them, so I am within all that is created and yet beyond it.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.34)

125 My devotee has bound Me in the lotus of his heart; wherever his eyes fall, there he sees Me.’

126 “He whose heart is never left by Hari Himself — Hari, who destroys hosts of sins even when His name is uttered helplessly — and who holds the Lord’s lotus feet fast with the cord of love, is called the foremost of the *bhāgavatas*.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.55)

127 “One who sees the Lord, the Soul of all, present in all beings, and sees all beings in the Lord, is the best of devotees (*bhāgavatottama*).” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.45)

128 “Singing loudly of Him alone, the *gopīs* searched together from forest to forest like madwomen. They asked the trees about that Person who, like the sky, is present within and without all beings.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.30.4)

129 Therefore the *Bhāgavata* speaks of these three: it consists of *sambandha*, *abhidheya* and *prayojana*.

130 “The knowers of the Truth call the non-dual knowledge the Truth; it is named Brahman, Paramātmā and Bhagavān.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.2.11)

131 This is *sambandha*. Now hear of the *abhidheya*, *bhakti*, whose presence pervades every verse of the *Bhāgavata*.

132 “I, the dear Self of the saintly, am attained by single-minded devotion born of faith. Devotion fixed on Me purifies even dog-eaters from the stain of their birth.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.14.21)

133 Now hear of *prema*, the chief *prayojana*, whose signs are the thrill of rapture, tears, dancing and singing.

134 “Remembering Hari, who takes away hosts of sins, and reminding one another of Him, they bear bodies thrilled by the devotion (*prema-bhakti*) born of devotion (*sādhana-bhakti*).” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.3.31)

135 “One who has taken this vow, chanting the names of his beloved Lord, finds love awakening within him; his heart melts, and, heedless of the world, he laughs aloud, weeps, cries out, sings and dances like a madman.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.40)

136 Therefore the *Bhāgavatam* is the meaning of the *sūtras* in embodied form: it is by nature the author’s own commentary on the *sūtras* he himself composed.

137 “This book named *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam*, of eighteen thousand verses, is the meaning of the *Brahma-sūtras*; it settles the meaning of the *Mahābhārata*; it has the form of a commentary on the Gāyatrī; and it is enriched by the meaning of the Vedas.” (Garuḍa Purāṇa)

138 "… the very essence of all the Vedas and Itihāsas, extracted." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.3.42)

139 "*Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* is held to be the essence of all Vedānta. One who is satisfied with the nectar of its *rasa* is never attracted to anything else." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 12.13.15)

140 This book begins with the meaning of the Gāyatrī: "*satyaṁ param*" (the Supreme Truth) is the *sambandha*, and "*dhīmahi*" (let us meditate) is both the practice (*sādhana*) and the goal (*prayojana*).

141 "Let us meditate on the Supreme Truth, from whom, directly and indirectly, this universe arises, endures and dissolves; who is fully aware of all purposes and shines by Himself (*svarāṭ*); who revealed the Veda through the heart to the first poet, Brahmā; about whom even the wise are bewildered; in whom, as fire, water and earth pass into one another, the threefold creation is real; and who by His own power is ever free of all deception." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.1)

142 "In this beautiful *Bhāgavatam*, composed by the great sage, is taught the supreme dharma of the saintly who are free from envy, from which all deceit has been cast out. Here is known the true Reality, which bestows good and uproots the threefold miseries. What need is there of other scriptures? As soon as the pious wish to hear it, the Lord is at once captured within their hearts." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.2)

143 The *Śrī Bhāgavatam* is the very form of the *rasa* of devotion to Kṛṣṇa; therefore its greatness surpasses that of the Vedic scriptures.

144 "O *rasikas*, O *bhāvukas* on earth! Again and again drink the *Bhāgavatam*, the ripe fruit fallen from the wish-fulfilling tree of the Vedas, filled with nectarean juice from the mouth of Śuka: drink its *rasa*, which embraces even the bliss of liberation." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.3)

145 “We are never satiated with the exploits of Uttamaśloka, for to those who know *rasa* and hear of them they grow sweeter and sweeter at every step.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.19)

146 Therefore study the *Bhāgavatam* carefully: from it you will gain the essential meaning of the *sūtras* and the *śruti*.

147 Always chant the name of Kṛṣṇa in *saṅkīrtana*: you will easily attain liberation, and you will attain the treasure of love.

148 “One who has realised Brahman and is serene within neither grieves nor desires. Equal to all beings, he attains supreme devotion to Me.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 18.54)

149 “Even the liberated, assuming a form (*vigraha*) by the Lord’s *līlā*, worship Bhagavān.” (words of the author of the Sarvajña-bhāṣya, quoted by Śrīdhara Svāmī in his commentary on Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.87.21)

150 “O royal sage, although I was firmly established in transcendence of the *guṇas*, my mind was captivated by the pastimes of Uttamaśloka, and so I studied this narration.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.1.9)

151 “The breeze that bore the fragrance of tulasī, mingled with the pollen of the lotus-eyed Lord’s lotus feet, entered their nostrils and stirred both their minds and their bodies, though they were devoted to the imperishable Brahman.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.15.43)

152 “Even sages who delight in the ātmā and are free from the knots of the heart render causeless devotion to Urukrama, for such are the qualities of Hari.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.7.10)

153 Just then the brāhmaṇa from Mahārāṣṭra told the assembly how that verse had been explained.

154 “The Lord has explained the meaning of this verse in sixty-one ways; all who hear it are amazed.”

155 Then everyone insisted on hearing them, and the Lord unfolded the sixty-one meanings in detail.

156 Hearing them, the people were struck with wonder and concluded that Caitanya Gosāñi is Śrī Kṛṣṇa Himself.

157 Having said this, Gaurahari rose and left, and the people bowed down to Him, calling out the name of Hari.

158 All the residents of Kāśī took up the *saṅkīrtana* of the Name; in love they laughed, wept, sang and danced.

159 The *sannyāsīs* and *paṇḍitas* began to study the *Bhāgavatam*. Thus the Lord delivered the city of Vārāṇasī.

160 Taking His own people with Him, the Lord came back to His lodging. Vārāṇasī had become a second Nadīyā.

161 Surrounded by His own associates, the Lord said with a smile, “I came to Kāśī to sell My wares of ecstatic feeling (*bhāva*).

162 In Kāśī there were no buyers, and the goods would not sell; yet they could not be carried back home again.

163 I would have carried the load back, but you were all grieved; so, by your wish, I have given it away free of charge.”

164 Everyone said, “You have descended to deliver the people. You have delivered the east, the south and the west.

165 Vārāṇasī alone was turned away from You; by delivering it, You have made us all happy.”

166 When the uproar arose in the town of Vārāṇasī, people from the villages and the countryside heard of it and began to come.

167 People came in hundreds of thousands, in millions, beyond counting; in that cramped place they could not get a sight of the Lord.

168 Whenever the Lord went to bathe or to see Viśveśvara, people lined both sides of the way to behold Him.

169 Raising His arms, the Lord would say, “Say ‘Kṛṣṇa!’ Say ‘Hari!’” and the people fell down before Him, calling out the name of Hari.

170 In this way the Lord delivered the people for five days; the next day He set out, His heart uneasy.

171 When the Lord rose at night and set off, five devotees followed close behind Him:

172 Tapana Miśra, Raghunātha, the brāhmaṇa from Mahārāṣṭra, Candraśekhara and Paramānanda the *kīrtana* singer — these were the five.

173 All of them wished to go to Nīlācala with the Lord, but He took leave of them all with loving care:

174 “Whoever wishes may come later to see Me; now I shall go alone by the path through Jhārikhaṇḍa.”

175 To Sanātana He said, “Go to Vṛndāvana. Your two brothers have already gone there.

176 My penniless devotees, who own only a patched quilt and a water pot — when they come to Vṛndāvana, take care of them."

177 Saying this, the Lord embraced them all and departed, and they all fell to the ground unconscious.

178 After a while they got up and returned home in sorrow, and Sanātana Gosāñi set out for Vṛndāvana.

179 Meanwhile, when Rūpa Gosāñi came to Mathurā, Subuddhi Rāya met him at Dhruva-ghāṭa.

180 Formerly, when Subuddhi Rāya was a governor (*adhikārī*) in Gauḍa, Saiyad Husain Khān was in his service.

181 Rāya put him in charge (*munsīph*) of digging a large pond; finding a fault in his work, Rāya struck him with a whip.

182 Later, when Husain Khān became king of Gauḍa, he greatly advanced Subuddhi Rāya.

183 His wife saw the marks of the whipping on his body and urged the king to have Subuddhi Rāya killed.

184 The king said, "Rāya has been my patron; he is a father to me. That I should kill him — such talk is not right."

185 His wife said, "If you will not take his life, then take his caste." The king said, "If his caste is taken, he will not survive."

186 His wife threatened to die, and the king was caught in a dilemma. At last he had water from a Muslim's water pot (*karoyā*) put into Subuddhi Rāya's mouth.

187 Taking this as his pretext (*chadma*), Subuddhi Rāya gave up all his worldly affairs and came to Vārāṇasī.

188 He asked the *paṇḍitas* what atonement he should perform. They said, “Drink boiling ghee and give up your life.”

189 Another said, “Not so: the fault is slight.” Hearing this, Rāya was left in doubt.

190 Then, when Mahāprabhu came to Vārāṇasī, Rāya met Him and told Him his story.

191 The Lord said, “Go from here to Vṛndāvana and always chant the name of Kṛṣṇa in *saṅkīrtana*.

192 By the mere semblance of the Name (*nāmābhāsa*) your sins and faults will go; and by chanting the Name itself you will attain Kṛṣṇa’s feet.

193 Chanting Kṛṣṇa’s name further, you will dwell in Kṛṣṇa’s abode. This is the atonement even for the greatest sins.”

194 Receiving this order, Rāya set out for Vṛndāvana and, by way of Prayāga and Ayodhyā, came to Naimiṣāraṇya.

195 Rāya stayed some days in Naimiṣāraṇya; meanwhile the Lord went from Vṛndāvana to Prayāga.

196 Coming to Mathurā, Rāya received news of the Lord; having missed meeting Him, he was deeply grieved.

197 Rāya would gather dry wood and sell it in Mathurā, earning five or six *paisā* a bundle.

198 He himself lived on one *paisā*'s worth of chickpeas and kept the rest of his money with a merchant.

199 Whenever he saw a poor Vaiṣṇava, he fed him; and when Gauḍīyas came, he gave them yogurt and rice and had them massaged with oil.

200 When Rūpa Gosāñi came, Rāya showed him great affection, took him along and showed him the twelve forests.

201 Rūpa Gosāñi stayed in Vṛndāvana only a month; then he quickly set out in search of Sanātana.

202 The Lord had come to Prayāga by the path along the bank of the Gaṅgā; hearing this, the two brothers went by that same path.

203 Meanwhile Sanātana Gosāñi, having come to Prayāga, went on to Mathurā by the royal road.

204 In Mathurā Subuddhi Rāya met him and told him all the news of Rūpa and Anupama.

205 The two brothers went by the Gaṅgā path and Sanātana by the royal road; that is why he did not meet them.

206 Subuddhi Rāya showed Sanātana great affection, but Sanātana would not accept an affection rooted in worldly relationships (*vyavahāra-sneha*).

207 Supremely renounced, Sanātana wandered from forest to forest, staying night and day now under one tree, now in another grove.

208 He collected the scriptures on the glories of Mathurā and, wandering through the forests, brought the lost holy places to light.

209 Thus Sanātana stayed in Vṛndāvana, while the two brothers, Rūpa Gosāñi and Anupama, came to Kāśī.

210 There Rūpa met the three — the brāhmaṇa from Mahārāṣṭra, Candraśekhara and Tapana Miśra.

211 He lodged in Candraśekhara's house and took his meals in Miśra's house, and from Miśra he heard the teachings the Lord had given Sanātana.

212 Hearing from the three about the Lord's deeds in Kāśī, and of His mercy to the *sannyāsīs*, he was overjoyed.

213 Seeing the people's reverence for Mahāprabhu and hearing *kīrtana* from their lips, he rejoiced.

214 After staying ten days, Rūpa set out for Gauḍa. Thus I have told the story of Sanātana and Rūpa.

215 Meanwhile, as Mahāprabhu went toward Nīlādri, He felt great joy on the solitary forest path.

216 Happily the Lord journeyed on with Balabhadra and, as before, sported in many ways with the deer and other creatures.

217 Coming to Āṭhāranālā, He sent the brāhmaṇa Bhaṭṭācārya ahead to call His devotees.

218 Hearing the news, the devotees seemed to come back to life — as the senses rise up when life returns to the body.

219 Overwhelmed with bliss, the devotees came running; at Narendra lake they all met the Lord.

220 The Lord bowed at the feet of Purī and Bhāratī, and both of them embraced Mahāprabhu with love.

221 Svarūpa Dāmodara, Gadādhara Paṇḍita, Jagadānanda, Kāśīśvara, Govinda, Vakreśvara,

222 Kāśī Miśra, Pradyumna Miśra, Dāmodara Paṇḍita, Haridāsa Ṭhākura and Śaṅkara Paṇḍita —

223 these and all the other devotees fell at the Lord's feet, and the Lord, embracing them all, was overwhelmed with love.

224 All the devotees floated in an ocean of bliss. Taking them all with Him, the Lord went to see Jagannātha.

225 Seeing Jagannātha, the Lord was overwhelmed with love, and for a long time He danced and sang with the devotees.

226 Jagannātha's servants brought garlands and *prasāda* and gave them to Him, and Tulasī, the *paḍichā*, came and bowed at His feet.

227 "Mahāprabhu has come!" — the town was in an uproar, and Sārvabhauma, Rāmānanda and Vāṇīnātha came to meet Him.

228 Taking everyone with Him, the Lord came to His residence at Kāśī Miśra's house, and Sārvabhauma and Gadādhara Paṇḍita invited Him to a meal.

229 The Lord said, "Bring the *mahā-prasāda* here: today I shall eat here with everyone."

230 Then the two of them brought Jagannātha's *prasāda*, and Mahāprabhu ate with everyone.

231 Thus I have told how the Lord, after seeing Vṛndāvana, journeyed back to Nīlādri.

232 Whoever hears this with faith will soon attain the feet of Caitanya.

233 Thus I have given a brief survey of the Madhya-līlā — how for six years the Lord travelled away and came back.

234 The last eighteen years He lived in Nīlācala, enjoying the pastimes of *kīrtana* with His devotees.

235 Now I shall recapitulate the Madhya-līlā in order, for in recapitulation the narrative is relished anew.

236 In the First Chapter: a synopsis of the final pastimes, with some parts described in detail.

237 In the Second Chapter: a description of the Lord's ecstatic utterances (*pralāpa*), with a brief survey of various *bhāvas*.

238 In the Third Chapter I have told of the Lord's *sannyāsa* and of His pastimes in the house of the Ācārya.

239 In the Fourth: the relishing of Mādhava Purī's life, the installation of Gopāla, and the story of the stolen sweet rice (*kṣīra*).

240 In the Fifth: the story of Sākṣi-gopāla, which Nityānanda told and the Lord relished.

241 In the Sixth: how the Lord delivered Sārvabhauma. In the Seventh: His pilgrimage and the deliverance of Vāsudeva.

242 In the Eighth: the conversation with Rāmānanda in detail, in which the Lord Himself heard “the essence of all conclusions.”

243 In the Ninth I told of His tour of the holy places of the South; in the Tenth, of His meeting with all the Vaiṣṇavas.

244 In the Eleventh: the *beḍā-saṅkīrtana* around the Śrī Mandira; in the Twelfth: the cleaning and washing of the Guṇḍicā temple.

245 In the Thirteenth: the Lord’s dancing before the chariot; in the Fourteenth: His witnessing of the Herā-pañcamī festival.

246 Within it is the hearing of the *bhāvas* of the divine maidens of Vraja: Svarūpa described them, and the Lord relished them.

247 In the Fifteenth: the Lord Himself spoke of His devotees’ virtues, took a meal at Sārvabhauma’s house and delivered Amogha.

248 In the Sixteenth: the journey toward Vṛndāvana by way of Gauḍa, and the return to Nīlācala from Nāṭaśālā.

249 In the Seventeenth: the journey to Mathurā by the forest path; in the Eighteenth: His wanderings in pastimes through Vṛndāvana.

250 In the Nineteenth: the journey from Mathurā to Prayāga, and within it the infusion of *śakti* into Śrī Rūpa.

251 In the Twentieth Chapter: the meeting with Sanātana, and within it a description of the nature (*svarūpa*) of Bhagavān.

252 In the Twenty-first: a description of Kṛṣṇa’s majesty and sweetness; in the Twenty-second: an explanation of the two kinds of *sādhana-bhakti*.

253 In the Twenty-third: an account of the *rasas* of *prema-bhakti*; in the Twenty-fourth: an explanation of the meanings of the *ātmārāma* verse.

254 In the Twenty-fifth: how the residents of Kāśī were made Vaiṣṇavas, and the return from Kāśī to Nīlācala.

255 Thus I have recapitulated the twenty-five chapters; by hearing this, one relishes the meaning of the book.

256 I have told the essence of the Madhya-līlā in brief; its full extent could not be described even in millions of books.

257 To deliver the *jīvas*, the Lord wandered from land to land; relishing *bhakti* Himself, He revealed it to the world.

258 The truth of Kṛṣṇa, the truth of *bhakti*, the truth of *prema*, the truth of *bhāva*, the truth of *rasa*, and the essence of the truth of *līlā* —

259 these, and the truth and *rasa* of the *Śrī Bhāgavatam*, He preached; and He made known to the world that the *Bhāgavatam* is equal to Kṛṣṇa.

260 For the sake of His devotees He expounded these truths with His own lips; and sometimes He had His devotees speak them and listened Himself.

261 In the three worlds I see no one else as merciful, as magnanimous and as affectionate to His devotees as Śrī Caitanya.

262 O devotees, hear these pastimes with faith: by hearing them you will attain the feet of Caitanya.

263 By its grace you will attain the essence of the truth of Kṛṣṇa; here you will reach the far shore of the conclusions of all the scriptures.

264 Kṛṣṇa's *līlā* is the essence of nectar, and that from which its hundreds upon hundreds of streams flow in all ten directions is Caitanya's *līlā* — an inexhaustible lake. Let the swan of your mind roam there.

265 O devotees, hear my humble words. Making the dust of your feet the ornament of my body, I make a petition to you.

266 In that lake the conclusions of devotion to Kṛṣṇa are a forest of blossoming lotuses: relish their honey. And in the forest of *kumuda* lilies — the *rasa* of *prema* — which blooms night and day, let the bees of your mind roam.

267 Devotees of various *bhāvas* are the swans and *cakravāka* birds who all sport in that lake; Kṛṣṇa's play is the lotus stems, and finding them at all times the devotee-swans feed on them.

268 Go to that lake, become swans and *cakravākas*, and sport there for ever. All your sorrows will be cut away, you will attain the highest happiness, and the elation of *prema* will come without effort.

269 The *sādhus* and great souls, like clouds, constantly shower this nectar on the garden of the world. From it grow nectarean fruits; the devotees eat them constantly, and by their love the people of the world live.

270 Caitanya's *līlā* is a filling of nectar (*amṛta-pūra*), and Kṛṣṇa's *līlā* is fine camphor; combined, the two become an exquisite sweetness. Whoever relishes it by the grace of the *sādhus* and the guru knows the abundance of that sweetness.

271 If a devotee takes food and drink without the nectar of this *līlā*, his life grows feeble; but by drinking a single drop of it he blossoms in body and mind, and laughs, sings and dances.

272 Drink this nectar, which has no equal, with firm faith in your heart. Do not fall into the pit of false argument, into its impure and harsh whirlpool: whoever falls there meets total ruin.

273 Śrī Caitanya, Nityānanda, Śrī Advaita, the assembly of devotees, and all you devotees who listen — I make your holy feet the ornament of my head, for from them comes the fulfilment of every cherished desire.

274 Holding on my head the feet of Śrī Rūpa, Sanātana, Raghunātha and Jīva, in whom I place my hope, lowly Kṛṣṇadāsa tells a little of the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*, which is filled with the nectar of Kṛṣṇa's *līlā*.

275 "For the satisfaction of Śrīman Madana-Gopāla and Govinda-deva, may this *Caitanya-caritāmṛta* be offered to Śrī Caitanya."

276 "This most secret nectar of Gaura's *līlā* is indeed not honoured by the mass of people: to them it is unattainable. What loss is that to me? Relished on all sides by the large-hearted and noble-minded, it expands their joy."